Ironically, in February 2014, Mamata and Anna addressed a press conference together where Anna promised to support the Trinamool leader in the general elections. ‘She is an honest politician, I like her simplicity,’ gushed Anna. ‘Annaji is like a father figure to us,’ Mamata said with equal feeling. Obviously, Taj Palace, December 2011, had been forgotten!

The ‘alliance’ between the ‘simple woman’ and the Gandhian lasted less than a month. A rally at Ramlila Maidan, hyped as Mamata’s grand entry onto the national stage, was a flop show, attracting only a few thousand people. Anna himself stayed away, citing ill health. When I went to see him in Maharashtra Sadan, he claimed to be on a soup diet. A few minutes earlier, former army chief, General V.K. Singh, who had just joined the BJP, had met him. The buzz was that Singh had gently ‘persuaded’ Anna to keep away from the Mamata rally.

The fiasco with Anna virtually ended Mamata’s 2014 dream of playing a greater role in Delhi. She, like many regional leaders, had been hoping to forge a post-election ‘Federal Front’, a coalition of non-Congress, non-BJP chief ministers. My own view is that Mamata, a shrewd politician, knew that a broader, national-level third front was always going to prove difficult. Her real concern was that the enemy number one—the left—was trying to cement a similar national alliance of its own. ‘The left will be left out,’ is how she once put it to me.

Mamata hated the left. It was a visceral hatred that stemmed from years of fighting a lonely battle as the Opposition in Bengal. She could do business with anyone but them. It appeared a limited political world view. She didn’t really care beyond a point who became prime minister as long as the bhadralok of Kolkata’s Alimuddin Street were kept at bay. ‘You don’t know, Rajdeepji, these leftists want to kill me,’ she told me once.

To isolate the left further, Mamata even reached out to Tamil Nadu chief minister Jayalalithaa and spoke to her about future alignments. If Mamata was mercurial, then Jayalalithaa could be fire on ice. While Mamata would display her tantrums in public, Jayalalithaa maintained a steely demeanour at all official engagements. If Mamata was the quintessential streetfighter, Jayalalithaa was imperious in her style. ‘She just had to look at you without